

■ By Kimi Dangor

International brands like Jimmy Choo and Gucci may be waltzing their way to the Indian fashion-scape, armed with stilettos, sling-backs, platforms and thongs, but footwear fetishists and desi Cinderellas needn't despair. Home-grown shoe designers are going cutting edge and launching a well-heeled and pumped up sartorial strategy.

As fashion sees an increasing specialisation and accessories become

an intrinsic part of any couturier's collection, shoes have gone from being an afterthought to central style statement. Manish Arora's successful tie-up with Reebok not only sold nearly 3,000 pairs of his trademark fluorescent footwear last year, they also hope to double sales figures this year with the recently opened Reebok Fish Fry store in Delhi. While Rajesh Pratap has carried over his simplistic finesse to footwear, there is a rising band of exclusive footwear designers who are not only leaving their retail footprints

across the country, but are also becoming an intrinsic part of fashion week fiestas and gaining a firm foothold.

Sunil Sethi of Alliance Merchandising, who has facilitated exports of

HEELS OVER HEAD

Even as international shoe brands make a high-heeled beeline for Indian shores, desi designers are taking the footwear route to fame



BIRENDRA HIGGINS His shoes are European in their appeal—tapered and low-rise for a good fit. Prices: Rs 5,000 onwards.



PAYAL KOTHARI Chic, fashionable and utterly feminine, her label Veruschka is a favourite with designers for catwalk shows. Prices: Rs 2,000 onwards.